

FINAL RESEARCH REPORT

GREEN NUDGES IN DIGITAL SHOPPING

Understanding Gen Z's Attitudes and Actions towards Eco-Conscious Tags and Nudges

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This study explores how Gen Z shoppers perceive and respond to green nudges, such as eco-labels, sustainability tags, and “lower carbon” defaults, during digital shopping. Through semi-structured narrative interviews and a draw-your-experience activity with six Gen Z shoppers aged 18-28, this study shows that although Gen Z is purported to be the most eco-conscious generation, practical factors, such as price, convenience, and perceived quality, take precedence, creating a significant value-action gap. Researchers found that participants care about the environment but believe that individual actions, such as purchasing power, do not make a meaningful difference, especially when green options are perceived as more expensive. Researchers also found that green nudges are interpreted through a lens of institutional responsibility and platform trust. Many participants believed that responsibility lies first with institutions and were skeptical of greenwashing practices and the shifting of responsibility onto individuals. This study underscores for corporations, policymakers, and other key players in sustainability that green nudges are effective only when they minimize financial and effort costs, are backed by verifiable corporate action, and align with a Gen Z individual’s social norms.

MOTIVATION AND BACKGROUND

Motivation

In recent years, sustainability has become a defining global concern, with Gen Z emerging as one of the most environmentally conscious generations. Studies highlight that Gen Z values transparency, eco-friendly practices, and social responsibility in the platforms they shop on and support (Brand et al., 2022; Dabija et al., 2019). Additionally, studies show that some are willing to pay more for sustainable products, despite limited financial means (Nielsen, 2022). However, while their attitude may reflect strong concern for the planet, a significant gap remains between their intentions and their actual purchasing behavior (Teather & Etterson, 2023).

Online shopping is a dominant mode of consumption for Gen Z consumers, offering a unique space where green nudges, eco-conscious tags, social proof messages, and default sustainable options can influence consumer decisions (Kaur, 2024). Research suggests that such nudges reduce consumers' cognitive effort in identifying sustainable products and motivate eco-friendly choices (Beermann et al., 2022; Gossen et al., 2022). However, the studies on the effectiveness of these are mixed, often complicated by consumer skepticism regarding price dynamics and concerns about greenwashing (Tunley Environmental, 2024; Purushothaman, 2023). This difference in opinion highlights the ambiguity and provides an opportunity for further research.

Our study is motivated by this tension: eco-conscious nudges offer an opportunity to guide Gen Z towards sustainable consumption, but their impact is far from straightforward. By examining how Gen Z perceives and responds to various eco-conscious labels during online shopping, the researchers aimed to identify both the opportunities and limitations of these

strategies. Given the multitude of green nudges, it is essential to assess their relative effectiveness and the factors contributing to their efficacy to advance a broader agenda that impacts the planet, thereby promoting sustainability both environmentally and economically. Ultimately, this research aimed to contribute to a more transparent and practical approach that aligns with consumer values, guiding them through the shopping process and encouraging them to make more sustainable decisions.

Background

As the most environmentally conscious and digitally active generation, Gen Z **tends to look out for authenticity, transparency, and social accountability from brands**. Gen Z exhibits a strong orientation towards sustainability, valuing brands that adopt eco-friendly or “green” practices and demonstrate social responsibility, compared to prior generations. Dabija, in their paper, emphasizes that Gen Z shows increasing interest in companies that implement “green strategies, either in the production processes or in marketing them under sustainable principles,” and are willing to pay a premium for such products despite being relatively young and less financially independent (Dabija et al., 2019). However, their attitudes and beliefs often conflict with real behaviour, due to obstacles such as convenience and the risk of greenwashing. This study sought to uncover the reasons for the “value–action gap” as a research challenge and explore ways to make digital nudging more sustainable (Teather & Etterson, 2023; Tunley Environmental, 2024).

According to the literature review, digital nudges, such as eco-labels, social proof, default sustainable settings, and information cues, represent an intuitive and rewarding method of designing green nudges without compromising personal agency. These nudges leverage psychological biases, such as the default bias and social validation, to reduce cognitive burdens for users and drive movement from awareness to action (Beermann et al., 2022; Kaur, 2024). There are many different kinds of labels, including green labels and certifications, information provision nudges, social proof and norms messaging, optional or default nudges, feedback and salience nudges, choice architecture and positioning nudges, incentives and rewards, and more. However, the effectiveness of nudges depends on the credibility of the information they provide, their visual ease of reading, and whether they make sense in the context. Therefore, poorly crafted nudges or excessive information can erode trust, while authentic messaging and verifiable certifications can strengthen positive actions (Hameed & Waris, 2018; Gossen et al., 2022).

When comparing different industries side by side, there are differences in how they apply these eco-labels. For example, both Amazon and Target are e-commerce retailers that use eco-labels on their products. Still, there are no clear guidelines that regulate how these eco-labels should be used across the entire retail industry. Conversely, those that sell beauty products (e.g., Sephora, MAC, etc.) have developed more substantial and visible ecosystems, including returnable packaging and recycling programs. **The differences in nudges point to the need for a more systematic and transparent approach to communicating about sustainability across industries** (Richardson, 2025; Grant et al., 2025).

Insights from the researchers' analysis of social media use, including Instagram, YouTube, and Reddit, suggest that Gen Z has a range of mixed feelings about sustainability, including hopefulness, disillusionment, and practicality. Their ability to be environmentally conscientious is greatly hampered by awareness and access; thus, while they are passionate about sustainability, they do not see themselves as able to practice it. Additionally, through their activity on social media platforms, they are expressing greater distrust of sustainability-related claims made by companies or organizations.

More than half of Gen Z report a greater level of skepticism toward company or corporate claims surrounding sustainability than they do toward a company's overall objective. Many believe there is also a greater need for some degree of systemic accountability on the part of government and businesses to enable Gen Z to express their environmental conscience through consumption than there is for individual responsibility. Young consumers increasingly believe that systemic accountability is required of these two entities to create sustainable solutions (Brand et al., 2022). Finally, more young consumers are beginning to realize that achieving true sustainability may not require substituting eco-labeled products for traditional products. Buying products labeled 'green' does not necessarily mean buying into the idea of sustainable living (Eco Conscious vs Eco Friendly: Know the Key Differences, 2025).

This analysis considers eco-nudging to be not only a behavioral but also an ethical design opportunity. The literature argues that, for digital commerce, sustainable practices should go beyond persuasive marketing and focus on developing trustworthy, transparent systems that translate moral intentions into accessible actions. Specifically, when Gen Z deems sustainable engagement credible, integrated, and achievable through their everyday digital experiences, they do so in ways that position e-commerce retail platforms as more than just vendors but as integral parts of community-based environmental stewardship (Purushothaman, 2023).

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. How do Gen Z consumers with purchasing power in the United States aged 18-28 perceive and respond to different types of green nudges during key stages of online shopping on e-commerce platforms?

This question was the ultimate goal of this research: to find out what goes on in a Gen Z consumer's mind when introduced to eco-nudging during the various stages of the purchasing process. The secondary research reveals that Gen Z is the most environmentally conscious generation of consumers. Yet, simultaneously, there is a persisting value-action gap—wherever intentions professed toward sustainability are not always translated into complementary purchasing behavior (Teather & Etterson, 2023). This gap is often explained by convenience, affordability, limited exposure to credible sustainability information, and skepticism of corporate greenwashing. In the meantime, digital interfaces also offer unique opportunities to bridge this gap through green nudges—subtle behavioral design interventions such as eco-labels, social proof, feedback cues, and sustainable defaults (Tunley Environmental, 2024; Purushothaman, 2023).

However, existing research is largely quantitative and inconclusive about which types of nudges best resonate with Gen Z consumers, under what conditions they influence actual behavior change, and whether they are effective in influencing their decisions (Saraev, 2025; Grant et al., 2025).

While secondary research and competitor analysis show that most e-commerce websites use some type of eco-nudge, the user experience and emotional sentiment of Gen Z consumers toward these nudges remain uninvestigated. Existing literature seldom captures how Gen Z's responses toward sustainability across different phases of shopping—shifting from discovery to post-purchase—are shaped by trust, authenticity, and perceived manipulation. Furthermore, the secondary research social media content analyses revealed that Gen Z consumers subtly signal frustration with affordability, transparency, and performative sustainability, signaling skepticism that cannot be captured using today's survey-based research. The future primary research—through semi-structured narrative interviews and draw your experience—aimed to close the gaps by tracing the cognitive processes of reasoning behind Gen Z's responses to green nudges. This qualitative study sheds light on the circumstances under which eco-nudging intersects with real sustainable action rather than when it risks maintaining distrust or disengagement, and how this could inform more ethical and superior digital sustainability intervention design.

2. What influences Gen Z consumers' decision-making on sustainability when purchasing goods and services online?

Gen Z consumers' decision-making regarding sustainability and their actions when purchasing products online are driven by key factors such as transparency, authenticity, and social influence. They actively seek credible information about brands and sustainable products, valuing clear communication over random “eco” labels. While many are willing to reduce their overall consumption and adopt eco-friendly habits such as recycling, using public and shared transport, or avoiding single-use items, the high prices of products and the prevalence of greenwashing remain significant barriers.

In a study of online interactions, the researchers found four key factors of decision-making. First, the researchers discovered that Reddit users discuss the demand for proof of sustainable practices, including supply chain visibility and measurable environmental impact; they want these brands to have transparency & authenticity tied to any purchase. Second, high prices usually hinder participation, raising concerns that sustainability is exclusive to privileged groups. Third, Platforms like YouTube, Reddit, and Instagram normalize sustainable habits through community-driven education and influencer advocacy. Finally, Gen Z distrusts empty marketing claims, expecting brands to demonstrate genuine commitment through tangible action and certifications. This heightened consumer awareness has put pressure to move beyond just the symbolic “green” marketing. Brands must also consider affordability, verify sustainability claims, and innovate with circular design and transparent communication.

METHODS AND JUSTIFICATION

The first method utilized was **narration**. The purpose of this story-based activity was to gain insights into Gen Z consumers' cognitive and affective processes when using an online shopping website to observe design stimuli related to sustainability, such as eco-tags, green nudges, or sustainable defaults. This method allowed researchers to trace actual decision-making, perceptions, and motivations by capturing participants' verbalized thoughts as they engaged in a typical online shopping trajectory. The narration (think-aloud) method involved asking participants to share their screen and verbalize their thoughts as they performed a specific online shopping activity. The goal was to gain insight into how Gen Z consumers perceive, interpret, and respond to environmental aspects at each step of the shopping process, from discovery to checkout.

The next method employed was a **semi-structured interview**. After completing the task, the researcher conducted a brief reflection-style interview to **clarify the thoughts or emotions the participant expressed during** the session. This helped the researchers better understand the strengths and limitations of the existing nudges and how, according to consumers, these can be improved.

Finally, **the researchers** had a new group of users draw their experience. Participants drew their experience with eco-nudges encountered during online shopping to identify which UI elements (green icons, carbon messages, default options) were most persuasive. This revealed how interface design shapes sustainable purchasing decisions. The **draw your experience activity** was a participatory, visual method for capturing emotions and cognitive responses that often remain unspoken in interviews.

DATA COLLECTION PROCEDURES

The researchers aimed to recruit participants through various channels, including Slack, WhatsApp, and other online groups. The researchers utilized a screener survey to find participants (Appendix B). In total, the researchers engaged with six different participants (two per person) through these methods. Of these six participants, all were Gen Z online shoppers, aged 18 to 28, and were identified through convenience sampling. The researchers did not request identifiable demographic information beyond age, as they felt it was not relevant to the research.

The data collection process was as follows: during interviews, one researcher served as the interviewer and the other as the note-taker. The researchers did not want more than two researchers per interview to avoid overwhelming the participants. This team utilized a script to ensure researchers would all interview each participant in the same manner (Appendix C). The researchers used Otter.AI for recording and transcription to ensure they captured all aspects of the interviews. For the draw your experience session, the researchers recruited six participants to use sticky notes to draw any green nudges they remembered. The prompt was open-ended, asking participants to illustrate whatever came to mind when they heard the term "green nudges"; it could be text, graphics, or any other way they wanted to communicate their perception. The

motive of the exercise was to gauge what stayed with the participants as a green nudge when they aren't online shopping and how they felt about it.

The researchers began their data analysis by coding two of the six interviews individually and finding key themes throughout the transcripts. These themes were affinity-mapped with the key quotes pulled from the transcripts to create the codebook (Appendix D). The codebook was uploaded to Atlas.ti and used to guide the recoding of the first two interviews and the subsequent coding of the additional four interview transcripts and the draw your experience results (Appendix E). In terms of ethical considerations, the researchers informed the participants of AI recording software usage and required a consent form to be signed before the interview started (Appendix F). The researchers also anonymized all transcripts at the time of coding and ensured that the Google Drive folder and Atlas.ti were only accessible by the research team, the professor, and the teacher's assistant. In the key findings, the researchers will refer to participants by number, from P1 to P6 (Participant 1 to Participant 6).

KEY FINDINGS

1. Prioritizing practical considerations over sustainability

In secondary research, it was generally accepted that Gen Z cares deeply about sustainability and has a high sustainability awareness (Dabija et al., 2019). Although this generation has high sustainability awareness, there is a value-action gap in making eco-friendly choices. Practical considerations, such as price, convenience, urgency (shipping), and perceived product quality, impacted the participants' preferences and actions when shopping online.

Shipping was often the first nudge participants noticed, but they would often choose the most convenient option over the most sustainable. Some noted that they would choose the more sustainable option, but not for sustainability reasons; instead, they chose the least packaging so they'd have less to carry up the stairs or to throw away. Price was also a significant factor in the participants' decisions. Price was consistently mentioned in all the interviews as a key factor in determining whether individuals would purchase a particular product or make a sustainable purchase, as shown in quotes from P6, P2, and P1. Many noted that they weren't in a time in their lives or in a position to make sustainable choices because sustainable choices were generally seen as more expensive overall. In the draw your experience activity, figure 1 shows that a participant noted that the sustainable option was more likely to cost more.

This first finding indicates a more transactional norm in online shopping, given the lack of human factors involved. Notably, this shifted when participants' peers spoke about sustainability. Those with peers who cared about sustainability were more likely to talk about eco-awareness or the influence of their friends on their own sustainable practices, as noted in a quote by P2.

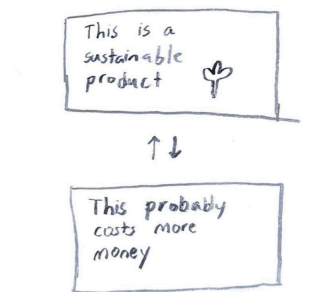
Quotes

"When it comes to shipping, I just go for whatever is cheapest." - P6

"I think as I get older, I would probably start switching towards more sustainable choices. But right now, as an international student, I feel like I'm constrained by price." - P1

"Sometimes I was just like, You know what? I just want to look nice, and I want to look pretty, so I'll buy something for cheap off of SheIn." - P2

"Well, I think I got more aware when my friend started her clothing brand, because she's very into sustainability, and she'll talk about it like no tomorrow. And so that made me really aware, because she was showing me how much waste comes from, like, clothing itself. She's like...[t]his is what happens when you don't thrift or, like, whatever. And I'll be like, okay, okay. And then, like, when you look at it, it's like, when you think about your life and how things affect your life, you don't really see it, but then you look at the bigger picture, and you're like, wow. So I think, like, she really got me into, like, paying attention to a point where it's like, if an eco-friendly option is \$5, \$10, \$15-\$20 bucks more, I'll go take it." - P2



(Fig 1: A participant noted during the Draw Your Experience activity that the sustainable product most likely costs more money.)

2. Intent and Action in Gen Z

The researchers observed a significant gap between stated environmental values and actual purchasing behavior. While they appreciate eco-friendly options and sustainability information, these factors rarely serve as primary drivers of decision-making. Eco-purchasing occurs when it is aligned with other priorities (aesthetics, social validation, practicality), not as a standalone motivator. Participants want concrete, guilt-free impact data showing collective difference rather than individual inadequacy. Sustainability is a "nice-to-have," not a "must-have."

Our participants' sustainability behaviors reveal a complex interplay between physical and digital contexts rather than simple consistency. The intent-action gap manifests differently across media, shaped by social dynamics and trust circles. P1's real-world eco-purchases are deeply motivated by interpersonal connection; buying recycled clothing specifically for its storytelling potential ("when someone compliments... I can let them know it's made from recycled jerseys"). This social validation and peer-to-peer trust transfer online demand collective-impact narratives ("1000 people like you make this decision"), suggesting that participants seek community

affirmation rather than isolated individual action. P3's Reformation purchases blend online research with brand identity ("I found something I liked... not purely just for being sustainable"), where brand storytelling and digital community create trust that influences their choices. However, this trust remains fragile. P3's surprise at discovering Tide's sustainability features during online browsing ("I didn't know this product has sustainability features") reveals how habitual in-store purchasing operates separately from eco-knowledge acquired online.

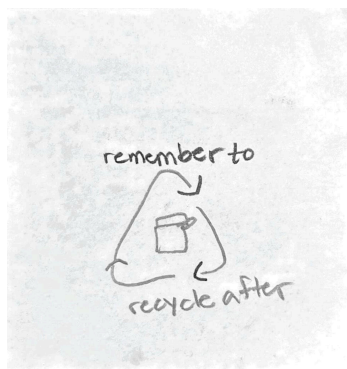
Quotes

"[T]he main problem with eco-friendly nudges is that I... would love to understand what kind of impact my purchasing decision can have. Maybe you can extrapolate... like if 1,000 people make this decision, then something meaningful happens... we can save something. Yeah, without guilt-tripping me." - P1

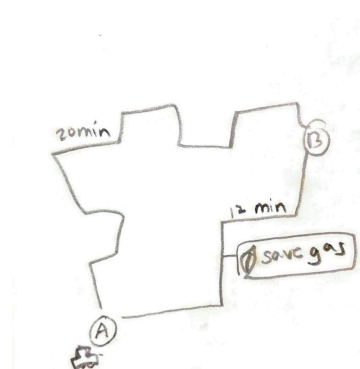
"A couple of clothing items I've bought were recycled or remade... it was just something cool to know. So when someone complimented me... I could say, 'Oh, this is made from recycled jerseys.' So I think mostly clothes... yeah." - P1

"I've made one or two purchases from Reformation because of their sustainability... and also because I found something I liked. It's not purely for sustainability... but it definitely influences me." - P3

"Looking at this energy-efficiency nudge... oh, interesting, I didn't know this product had sustainability features... because this is the usual Tide brand I buy. But to be honest... when I'm buying Tide Pods, I don't really look at sustainability features... but it's nice that it tells me it conserves energy compared to similar products." - P3



(Fig 2: A participant noted to remember to recycle during the Draw Your Experience)



(Fig 3: A participant noted a way to save gas using maps during the Draw Your Experience)

3. Perceived Power to Influence Outcomes

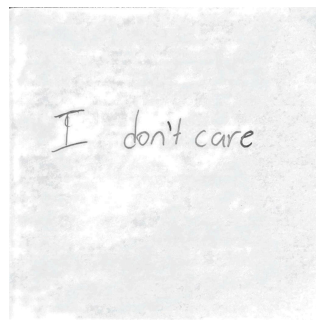
The researchers observed that most participants actively engage with specific data, such as CO₂ reductions, boxes saved, trips eliminated, and improved farmer welfare. Quantifiable outcomes create a sense of efficacy. Engagement with eco-nudges is directly proportional to

relatability of stated outcomes. Response to metrics and storytelling that connects their purchase was higher, but participants disengaged when the impact felt abstract or disconnected from their action (Fig. 4). They need affirmation that their individual purchase "does something." Eco-information serves as psychological validation that effort matters and counters feelings of insignificance. Positive framing matters; they prefer "craftsmanship" storytelling over sacrifice narratives. Most want to feel good about eco-purchases, about doing something positive for the environment, not guilty or compromised.

Quotes

"[B]ecause they had a more prominent I feel like the storytelling was better over there, where they started off by saying how they made this product, like they almost described it as, like craftsmanship. I think Nike does this very well, that they actually make you feel like, good about buying something like this, rather than you, you feel like, Oh, you're kind of compromising, but you're helping the planet." - P1

"[E]nergy efficient is always going to be one that I'm like, Oh, that's a cool, nice perk the harsh chemicals with my health and just other background knowledge I've had about cases of brands using chemicals that were not safe for human use. That one I'm a lot more picky about." - P6



(Fig 4: A participant noted during the Draw Your Experience activity that they simply do not care.)

4. Institution-First Responsibility Perception

Various participants feel that sustainability should be driven from the top down, which is through larger institutions, platforms, and brands, rather than from the bottom up through individualized choices. This viewpoint appears repeatedly in the data, with 4 of the 6 participants emphasising their low personal impact and stating that true change must come from a company-led initiative. In several responses, participants directly or indirectly indicate that the burden placed on individuals seems disproportionate to the scale of environmental issues.

This theme reinforces the broader pattern of treating sustainability as a second-order priority; participants will engage with more sustainable options only when they believe institutions are also pulling their weight. This reflects a relational dynamic whereby individual action seems meaningful to participants only within the context of tangible corporate accountability. It creates a foundational framework for evaluating any sustainability cue.

Engagement happens when the action feels collective rather than an individual duty. The researchers had expected more individual-oriented motivations from Gen Z; instead, the data challenged this assumption and pointed toward a structural awareness. The assumption of the approach that nudges are behaviour-modifying tools needs revision, considering the ways in which participants resist these when they sense misalignment of responsibility.

Quotes

"[B]ut on an individual level, I don't I've kind of struggled to feel any difference that I make by buying an eco friendly product, whether it's like higher cost or like, lower reliability. I feel like those are just like, it's not helping the planet too much." - P2

"But ultimately, the onus lies with the business, and they could be making more responsible decisions with how the way they run their business impacts the people who work there and the world in general, how much water they use things like that. " - P6

5. Platform Trust Shaping Sustainable Decisions

Participants' willingness to respond to eco-nudges depends significantly on how much they trust the platform through which the message is conveyed. Most expressed suspicion of Amazon in particular, questioning the authenticity of sustainability tags, eco-labels, and "lower carbon delivery," and whether these were anything more than greenwashing to cover their other environmental impacts. This distrust decreases the effectiveness of nudges; even when participants notice them, they are discounted unless the source feels transparent. At the same time, some participants compared Amazon with other platforms they perceive as more trustworthy, often because of clearer communication, stronger reputations, or more consistent sustainability practices that are evident even in their delivery practices. Trust operates as a filter. Only when the platform is credible or when users do not notice contradictory actions do nudges feel meaningful.

This reframes how participants interpret eco-nudges; rather than empowering nudges, some participants see them as deflections of responsibility, in conflict with their other corporate actions, and only for the sake of an initiative the organizations are undertaking to meet various sustainability requirements like the CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility). On the other hand, nudges that indicate corporate commitment and actual impact are perceived to be more authentic or worth recognition. The data points to how easily distrust can neutralize the intended cause. The actions of scepticism, eye-rolling, and avoidance suggest that participants are not rejecting sustainability itself but the legitimacy of the messenger. At the same time, selective trust, such as trusting eco-claims for skincare more than Amazon's labels, highlights how trust is both category-dependent and rooted in past brand experiences. This observation poses larger challenges with respect to the role of platform ethics, transparency, and brand reputation in informing sustainable behavior.

Quotes

"I think really strong statements here, but I kind of hate Amazon as a business. I think their eco nudges are honestly hypocritical, and it's like they as a business, already cause so much damage to the environment that it just feels like they're trying to pass the responsibility onto the consumer." - P6

"Green washing, where, of like recent big consumer brands have given off this impression of being sustainable, but when you read more about their practices. It's like, very vague and high level. You're not actually sure, like, what commitment they're making. Or there have been some companies like, I think recently, like Arterics was in the news for running some campaign, like a marketing campaign that was meant to be promoting sustainability but actually created a negative impact on the environment in which it was, like in the community that it was impacting." - P3

IMPACT

The study reveals how Gen Z  perceives and reacts to green nudges in the online shopping experience. The research indicated how the emotional, cognitive, and social components of Gen Z's purchasing decisions interact to shape their purchase intent. Consequently, UX designers and sustainability strategists could use the findings to better understand and implement such nudges. If eco-nudges are designed as networks of trust, emotion, and responsibility, they can be much more effective in helping Gen Z consumers make sustainable choices.

The study showed that sustainability, compared with other factors such as price, convenience, perception of quality, and the value of individualistic impact, raises a broader issue: negotiating value creation vs. a value-action gap. Additionally, the participants saw the role of responsible sustainability as shared responsibilities among "systems," leading to skepticism towards vague and inconsistent claims, demonstrating that trust and realism are critical factors in their understanding and response to sustainability. Finally, the research findings offer insights that support the concept of an effective design for sustainable e-commerce as much more than "superficial" or "performative" efforts, with an emphasis on the need for transparency, measurable impacts, and accountability on the part of institutions.

These research findings show a complex relationship between offline and online experiences, and, as such, they form part of a broader framework for understanding how sustainable behaviors develop and highlight that neither experience impacts in isolation. Examples of offline interactions that can influence how users experience eco-nudges in the digital environment include over-packaging products, how brands present themselves, and how peers influence one another. Therefore, any digital action taken to stimulate sustainable behavior needs to be incorporated into a user's overall experience, both offline and online, treating these areas as hybrid responsibilities. E-commerce businesses, such as Amazon, should develop sustainable communication strategies that clearly demonstrate their commitment to sustainability in real life and create consistent eco-cues in their interfaces to enhance users' understanding and confidence in those eco-cues.

The open-ended interviews and discussions based on sustainability scenarios allowed researchers to gather rich, descriptive qualitative data about participants' attitudes and reasons for their sustainability decisions. Instead of simply gathering information about how individuals participate in this area, the qualitative nature of these interviews and discussions revealed much more about the emotions, context, and reasoning behind sustainability choices, which any other method of data collection could not provide. With participants' emotional and behavioural tensions identified and understood, designers and organisations can consider these aspects when designing for sustainability, which takes into account the realities in which users live rather than assuming they will do what an ideal set of behaviors prescribes.

FUTURE WORK AND REFLECTION

This exploratory study with 6 Gen Z participants provided the researchers with rich qualitative insights, but lacked statistical generalizability. Here, the **key limitation is the self-report bias, where the interviews captured stated values** that often diverged from actual purchase behavior under budget constraints and time pressure. The observed intent-action gap may be even larger in authentic shopping contexts (online/offline). Since participants were asked to purchase laundry detergent on Amazon, their responses may not have reflected spontaneous decision-making patterns, habitual brand loyalty, or the influence of in-store versus online environments they typically navigate.

When conducting this research again, the researchers would start with a larger survey to identify different Gen Z shopper types, then observe them shopping naturally, whether restocking on Amazon, impulse-buying at Target, or price-comparing across platforms. In future research, the researchers would track shoppers over months to see if eco-nudges create lasting habits or just initial curiosity, and develop systems that adapt messaging based on whether someone prioritizes budget, ethics, or convenience. The researchers would also run workshops where Gen Z participants create their own trust-building labels, measuring whether people understand, believe, and feel respected by these designs, not just whether they notice them.

The study reveals that **Gen Z eco-consciousness is real but conditional**, constrained by affordability, overwhelmed by opacity, and skeptical of greenwashing. The intent-action gap persists not because of a lack of values, but because **current eco-nudges fail to address lived realities: tight budgets, decision fatigue, and justified corporate distrust**. Effective interventions must make sustainable choices on the path of least resistance through cross-disciplinary collaboration, designers creating friction-free interfaces, researchers validating trust mechanisms, industry providing genuine transparency, and policymakers establishing enforceable standards. With evidence-based design and systemic support, eco-nudges can evolve from performative gestures into genuine tools for collective impact.

Appendix

Appendix A: References

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Appendix B: Screener Survey

[You can view the screener survey here.](#)

Appendix C: Script

 Eco-Tags Protocol Script

Appendix D: Codebook

 EcoTags Codebook.docx

Appendix E: Atlas.ti Project

The project has been shared with your email, but you can also access it [via this link](#).

Appendix F: Consent Form

[You can view the consent form here.](#)